the firing trenches. Indian artillery guns and heavy mortars positioned on the eastern bank also came to their support, taking a heavy toll on the attacking Chinese troops. After 9 a. m., the Chinese infantry pulled back and the RCL guns continued to fire at the forward positions. This gradually began to take effect as some of the bunkers were seriously damaged forcing the Gorkhas to vacate them.

By midday, the remnants of the forward platoon on The Ladders were running critically low on ammunition. Naib Subedar Dil Bahadur, the company JCO, succeeded in partly resupplying the positions by braving Chinese fire. At 9 p. m., the Chinese put in yet another attack, but the Gorkhas managed to repulse it; by this time they were running desperately short of men and ammunition. An hour later, Chand radioed Behl asking for reinforcements. But the Sikh CO was fighting a number of battles all around and he was in no position to spare even a single man. After this conversation, the wireless communication between 4 Sikh Battalion HQ and The Ladders broke down. By then, the Chinese too seemed to have shifted their attention elsewhere and there were no further attacks on The Ladders during the night.

Shortly after Lieutenant Palta had warned the companies on the west bank about the Chinese advancing with torches, he had come under heavy bombardment from the guns deployed at the base of Ashi Hills. Convinced that the Chinese would attempt a river crossing under the cover of darkness, he warned his men to prepare themselves for an attack during the night.

Having got sufficient men across, the Chinese launched their first attack on High Plateau at 11.30 p.m. The Sikhs were waiting for them and met the Chinese with concentrated fire. Having got their attention, the Chinese on the slope leading up to High Plateau decided to stay where they were. At the same time a party was sent to cut off the connecting route from Dong Plateau and Dong Hill where Lieutenant Colonel Yadav’s Battalion HQ and two companies of 3/3 GR were deployed.

The second attack started at 1.30 a.m. on 16 December. As the Chinese crept up the slope, the Sikhs grimly held their positions. Palta radioed Yadav for reinforcements, then went back to exhorting his men to use their ammunition judiciously and make every round count. All this while, he was moving from bunker to bunker, throwing grenades at the advancing Chinese, while shouting curses at them. The lieutenant was hit once, but his voice did not die down, as he urged his men to hold their positions. Then he